

GitHub Repository Licensing

When discussing GitHub repository licensing, you're essentially deciding how other people are legally allowed to use your code. Without a license, your code is technically “all rights reserved”, meaning others cannot legally use, modify, or distribute it, even if it's public.

Why a GitHub License Matters

A license defines:

- Whether others can use your code
- Whether they can modify it
- Whether they can use it commercially
- Whether they must open-source their modifications

Without a license:

- People cannot legally reuse your code
- Companies won't touch your repository
- Contributions become legally unclear

Common Open Source Licenses

1. MIT License (Most Popular)

Simple and very permissive.

Permissions

- Use
- Modify
- Distribute
- Commercial use

Conditions

- Must include the original license and copyright

Good for

- Libraries
- Personal projects
- Developer tools

Example projects using MIT:

- React
- Vue.js

Example MIT header:

MIT License

Copyright (c) 2026 Your Name

Permission is hereby granted, free of charge, to any person obtaining a copy of this software...

2. Apache 2.0 License

Similar to MIT but includes patent protection.

Permissions

- Use
- Modify
- Distribute
- Commercial use

Extra

- Explicit patent grant

Used by:

- TensorFlow
- Kubernetes

Good for:

- Enterprise software
- Infrastructure tools

3. GPL License (Strong Copyleft)

Versions include:

- GNU General Public License v2
- GNU General Public License v3

Key rule

If someone uses your code in their project:

- Their project must also be open source under GPL

Used by:

- WordPress
- Linux Kernel

Good for:

- Projects where you want improvements shared publicly

4. BSD License

Very similar to MIT but slightly more formal.

Types:

- BSD 2-Clause
- BSD 3-Clause

Used by:

- FreeBSD

How to Add a License to a GitHub Repo

In GitHub:

1. Go to your repository
2. Click Add File
3. Click Create new file
4. Name it

LICENSE

Paste license text.

Or use GitHub's license tool:

1. Go to repository
2. Click Add License
3. Choose MIT / Apache / GPL

GitHub will automatically detect it.

Best License for Most Developers

For developer projects, portfolios, and libraries, use:

❖ MIT License

Reasons:

- Extremely common
- Minimal restrictions
- Companies can use it
- Easy contributions

Important Mistakes Developers Make

1. No license

Public repo but legally unusable.

2. Copy-pasting code without license compatibility

Example:

GPL code inside MIT project, legal conflict

3. Forgetting copyright

Always include:

Copyright (c) 2026 Your Name